

Delhi Heritage Guide

DEL001: Red Fort. Built by Mughal Emperor Shah Jahan in 1639, the Red Fort (Lal Qila) served as the main residence of the Mughal Emperors for nearly 200 years. Made of massive red sandstone walls, it represents the zenith of Mughal creativity under Shah Jahan. The fort's innovative architectural style beautifully blends Islamic, Persian, Timurid, and Hindu traditions. Key structures inside include the Diwan-i-Aam (Hall of Public Audience) and Diwan-i-Khas. The fort was heavily plundered during Nadir Shah's invasion in 1739. Today, it stands as a symbol of India's sovereignty, where the Prime Minister hoists the flag every Independence Day.

DEL002: Qutub Minar. Standing at 72.5 meters, the Qutub Minar is the tallest brick minaret in the world and a UNESCO World Heritage Site. Construction was initiated by Qutb-ud-din Aibak, the founder of the Delhi Sultanate, in 1192 to celebrate Muslim dominance in Delhi after the defeat of the last Hindu ruler. The tower features five distinct storeys, with the first three constructed of red sandstone and the upper two of marble and sandstone. The surrounding complex includes the Quwwat-ul-Islam Mosque, the first mosque built in India, and the mysterious Iron Pillar which has famously resisted rusting for over 1,600 years.

DEL003: India Gate. Originally known as the All India War Memorial, India Gate is a monumental sandstone arch in New Delhi, standing 42 meters tall. It was designed by Sir Edwin Lutyens and completed in 1931. The memorial commemorates the 70,000 soldiers of the British Indian Army who lost their lives fighting in World War I and the Third Anglo-Afghan War. The names of 13,300 servicemen are inscribed on its walls. Following the Indo-Pakistani War of 1971, the Amar Jawan Jyoti (Flame of the Immortal Soldier) was added beneath the arch to honor India's unknown martyrs.

DEL004: Humayun's Tomb. Commissioned in 1569 by Humayun's first wife, Empress Bega Begum, this magnificent tomb was the first garden-tomb on the Indian subcontinent. Designed by Persian architect Mirak Mirza Ghiyas, it was the first structure to use red sandstone at such a massive scale.

The tomb is a seminal masterpiece of Mughal architecture and is widely considered the direct architectural predecessor to the Taj Mahal. The complex includes a highly geometric Persian Charbagh (four-part garden) layout. It houses the graves of Emperor Humayun, his wife, and over 150 other Mughal family members, earning it the nickname 'Dormitory of the Mughals'.

DEL005: Lotus Temple. Dedicated in 1986, the Lotus Temple is a Bahá'í House of Worship famous for its striking flower-like shape. Designed by Iranian architect Fariborz Sahba, the structure is composed of 27 free-standing marble-clad 'petals' arranged in clusters of three to form nine sides. In accordance with Bahá'í teachings, the temple is open to all, regardless of religion or any other qualification, serving as a gathering place for people of all faiths to pray and meditate in silence. It is one of the most visited buildings in the world, surrounded by nine pools and spanning 26 acres.